

A return gaze from the first morning of 2008 is a survivor's luxury. There are those lucky ones, sighing in gratitude: being alive and basking in the first glow of the New Year is heaven indeed. They look back and realise how treacherous it has been, the ordeal of overcoming the passions and pathologies of the adversary who raises the ante at the first blink of the meekest, and it is unlikely that they look within and realise how much has been compromised in the pursuit of power—or is it the other way round, the power of pursuit? They may not be modest enough to acknowledge that what matters now is not an exaggerated sense of defeat or victory but the sheer joy of being here. Then, we don't expect anything else from the political class. The extremity of their arguments has made 2007 a year of confrontation.

We may console ourselves that we can't remain static; the state of confrontation is a necessary condition for India to remain democracy's action thriller without respite. Gloves are off and arguments are arrows when power is not absolute, when ideas of change make ideologies redundant. In India 2007, power was lame, desperate and morally shallow. It was all the more vulnerable as a rusty ideology challenged the big idea of the moderniser. The Marxists' anti-imperialism (ah yes, the last 'ism' of the desperate revolutionaries in places like Pyongyang, Caracas and Delhi) vs Manmohan Singh's Americanism may have killed the nuclear deal, but it has brought out the fragile balance of power in Indraprastha. The c-deficiency (c for conviction) of the prime minister was acute and the granite resoluteness of the apparatchik was terrifyingly real.

It was an unequal fight: not having the courage to stand by his idea, the defender was willing to forsake his principles; and the aggressor—the last receptacle of a fossilised fantasy—had that rare privilege of influencing power and intimidating those who wield it. So, in the end, the confrontation essays the contrast of the antagonists. Twenty-first century India is home to a prime minister for whom politics is still Greek and a cheerless commissar for whom the Soviet model is India's salvation. Elsewhere in India, another communist, our own McMarxist, thought it was time to break out of Sovietology (with due apologies to Comrade General Secretary) and bring Dengism to the wretched countryside of West Bengal. Finally what prevailed in Nandigram was the Stalinist beast that leapt from the Shenzhen promises of a chief minister with all the human credentials to become the Dubcek of Indian communism. Buddhadeb's *mea culpa* was redeeming, but the blood spilled

in the parched lands of Nandigram was redder than the flag of Prakash Karat.

If the confrontation in the rural remoteness of West Bengal was between the pretence and practice of Indian communism, in Gujarat, it was a clash of two ideas of Modi—one born out of the cult of ideological combativeness; the other assembled to horrific perfection by freelance Frankenstein's of official secularism. The most caricatured and the least understood politician in India today, Modi has been confronting his own image since 2002. In 2007, the clash was captured in catch phrases like "merchant of death" (authorship not his) and the "sultanate of Delhi" (copyright his). He won Gujarat; and India is yet to make up its mind on this man, the very mention of whose name can still launch a thousand arguments. In the years to come, the site where the idea of Modi will be tested will be larger than Gujarat—it will be in the mind of India. Modi was of course the idea that was magnified by the year of confrontation; the political arena was otherwise littered with dented egos and shattered reputations, stretching from the heartland to the deep south.

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In India's near abroad, though, the culture of confrontation had no safeguards of democracy. The defiance of barefoot monks for a while brought the images of Leipzig and Prague circa '89 to the streets of Burma. The saffron resistance could not withstand the jackboots of the junta, but the conscience of liberation was awakened. And as the year came to a close, in Pakistan, Benazir Bhutto lost her home forever as she confronted the evil accessorised by the Book and the Kalashnikov—and the evil that haunts us all. Will her martyrdom provoke, at last, the benefactors of the cruelest place on earth to confront the reality of Pakistan as the war room of jihad? The year 2008 will demand a convincing answer; perhaps the US presidential election will provide one. For India, though, the culture of confrontation is as old as its struggle for—and with—freedom. We may get a little more scarred by the combatants of 2008, and a lot more wiser too. ■